Most of the basic weapons used up to the gunpowder age already existed before the appearance of the first hierarchical "civilized" states around 5,000 years ago. Bows and arrows, spears, clubs, and edged weapons grew in effectiveness during the period covered in this chapter, notably through the use of new materials – evolving from stone to copper, bronze, and finally iron. But the essentials of slashing, stabbing, and launching missiles at an enemy remained unchanged. Apart from a few specialist machines for siege warfare, the only major technical innovation was the introduction of horses around 1700 BCE, first to pull chariots and then to mount cavalry.

HIERARCHY AND COMMAND

There were only quite limited variations in the military technology available to different societies, so the key area for the evolution of warfare was in the organization and motivation of fighting men. The Ancient World was characterized by a dazzling diversity of fighting methods. Tribal societies in which each adult male was a warrior would find themselves confronted by armies of trained, professional soldiers who had a career structure and a fixed term of service. Men fighting exclusively as mounted archers battled with armies committed to close-quarters infantry combat.

The first hierarchically organized armies known to historians appeared in the city-states of Sumeria, Mesopotamia, in around 3000 BCE. From then until around 1000 BCE, similar military

Greek warfare
Hoplites, depicted naked, although they would have worn armour, battle with spears. The 2–3m (7–9ft) spear was the hoplite's primary weapon. When forming a phalanx they would point these forward while locking their shields together.







